management and labour unions, Gandhi concentrated primarily on devising funding plans for the deal.

Tata Motors was not alone in its quest to bag the companies. Three others were in the fray—the Indian car maker Mahindra Group and the American equity firms Ripplewood Holdings and One Equity Partners, a unit of JP Morgan Chase & Co. Mahindra was assisted by a former Ford president and COO, Sir Nicholas Scheele, and the American firms by a former Ford CEO, Jacques Nasser.

Tata Motors' path was strewn with many challenges. Adverse newspaper reports stoked fear and apprehension among the Jaguar and Land Rover employees about the possible pitfalls of the ownership passing into Indian hands. Less than a year earlier, too, during the Corus acquisition, British newspapers had commented that extending credit to the Tata Group was risky. Ratan was advised patronizingly to 'pray' for deliverance. This time, too, it was no different, except that some newspapers also tried to quote some supposedly anonymous and isolated views from India to buttress their negative discourse. Some suspected that this was an effort to either scare the group away or at least portray to the seller that the Tatas may not be the best choice.

The *Financial Times* wrote a primer on why the Tatas should keep away from the British marquees. Their reasons ranged from questioning 'Tata's strategic fit with the high-end, low-volume UK brands' to suggesting their incapacity to deal with the 'fiendishly complicated transaction and integration process'. It went on to add that it was a time of 'downturn' for the 'Indian automotive market' and that the acquisition 'could even sink Tata Motors'.

It also cautioned Ratan that if he was thinking of 'post-sale' offshoring of some of the design and engineering work to India, he should 'tread carefully', because the Jaguar and the Land Rover had a 'large unionised workforce in the UK'. The daily went on to quote a banker characterizing the acquisition as a 'turn of the roulette table as far as Tata Motors' was concerned. It also predicted that the acquisition could put Tata Motors' cashflow 'under tremendous pressure'.

Across the Atlantic too, there were many critics. Among the first to target the Indian conglomerate was a group of dealers of the Jaguar brand. Ken Gorin, chairman of the US Jaguar Business Operations Council, ridiculed the possible acquisition, saying: 'I don't know that the United States